

Technical Report Writing (TRW)

Chapters No 12 & 14
(Applications)

Formal, Informal Reports & Memorandum

Chapter in a Nutshell

- What is a report?

- What is a formal report?

(Characteristics, elements and how to write?)

- What is an informal report?

(Characteristics and elements)

- What is a memorandum?

(Characteristics, elements and how to write informal reports, using a memorandum)

What is a report?

A report enables a writer to give, receive or share the official data or information. It is always in the written form. In other words a report is an official opinion, in the written form, based on research, facts and observation. A report promotes discussion and provides basis for the informed decision making of the competent authority. It also helps in sorting out problems and to make new recommendations. Even if a report is presented orally, yet it has a hard copy, which is written according to a standard format. A well written report reflects upon the information, ideas and work of both the author or the organization. Depending upon the purpose, the audience of a report may be one person, a committee, a board, other organizations and even members of the public. Similarly, depending upon the communication situation and the degree of formality, a report may be categorized as 'formal' or 'informal'. A report may be written within an organization (intra-organizational or in-house report) or from one organization to another organization (inter-organizational or firm to firm report).

What is a formal report?

(Characteristics and elements)

A formal report is written and presented in a special way to emphasize the importance of its contents and to make it appear more official. Writers often use formal reports to present recommendations or results of research. Moreover, other reasons for choosing a formal report format are: Length of content over 10 pages, breadth of circulation, perceived importance to the community and company policy. The contents of formal and informal report can be exactly the same, but the difference is in the changed perception caused by the formal presentation. Similarly, formal report format includes these characteristics: (title page, table of contents, executive summary or abstract, body of the report is presented in chapters and each chapter starts from the top of a new page, pages are numbered, both language and tone are also adequately formal, in the light of Chapter No. 4. of the book and a formal report is sent to its audience with a transmittal letter or memo; transmittal letter for firm to firm report and a memo for in-house report and a formal report is hard bound/jacketed and published).

What is an informal report?

(Characteristics and elements)

The informal report format is used for reports that will not have wide distribution, will not be published and are shorter than 10 pages.

(General Motors)

Memorandums are used to write various kinds of informal reports having above mentioned characteristics.

Informal reports have these following kinds:

- IMRD (Introduction, Methodology, Results, Discussion) Reports
- Brief Analytical Reports
- Progress Reports

NOTE: If for example in an organization a requirement arises where description is needed to be written for an audience, an officer, a senior, a subordinate, a committee and so on. It means this will be an in-house or intra-organizational document and hence falls into the category of an informal report. Hence, the description will be written in the light of chapter 10 and in the format of memorandum chapter 12.

Similarly, if it is a short research based report or in-house/intra-organizational report, it will also be written in the format of memorandum and in IMRD(Introduction, Methodology, Result, Discussion) form. In the same manner, brief analytical and progress reports will also be written in their formats in memorandums.

Memorandum

A memo is any document regardless of length that has memo heads (Date, To, From, Subject) at the top. (Classically heads should be at the top, however, popularly it may vary due to the formats in fashion). Whatever is written after these memo heads is called as memo report. Usually such report is brief; from one or two sentences to one or two pages. Theoretically there is no limit to a memo's length, but in practice such reports are seldom longer than four or five pages. The day-today operation of a company or organization depends on memos and informal reports (written in the form of memo reports after heads in their own respective methods) that circulate within and among its departments. Memos are used to report everything, like results of test, announcements of meetings, IMRD reports, analytical reports and progress reports etc. In industry, the ability to write memos clearly and quickly is highly regarded and considered as a requisite skill for efficient problem solving and decision making.

- Classically, place the (To, From and Subject) at the top left margin.
- Place date either to the right, without a head, or at the top above (To, From, Subject) with a head.
- Put colon after each head and then the information.
- Choose a method of capitalization.
- Name the content/central idea/purpose in the subject.
- Place the names of those people (if needed) who are to receive copies of the memo below the name of the main recipient, usually with a head **cc:**
- Sign to the right side of your typed name.
- After these memo heads, memo report can contain **ANY** kind of information, like one, two sentences, IMRD report, analytical report, progress report as is the requirement of the writer (maximum four, five pages traditionally)

IMRD Report

(Introduction, Methodology, Results, Discussion)

An IMRD report is a standard way to present information that is the result of some kind of research. This approach can present laboratory research, questionnaire results, or the results of any action whose goal is to find out about a topic and discuss the significance of what was discovered. It is written as a memo report under the memo heads in the form of a memorandum.

Introduction

Tell the readers the question you investigate (the goal of the project) and the point of the report. Simply, the writer answers these questions in this section:

What is the goal of this project?

What is the goal of this report?

Methodology

Write the process description(chapter 10) of your actions and why you performed those actions. Simply, the writer answers these questions in this section:

What steps or actions did you take to achieve the goal?

Why did you perform those actions?

Results

Tell the reader what you discovered, usually by presenting a table or graph of data. If text is added, tell the readers what to focus on. Honesty requires from a writer that the material which contradicts the expected results should also be presented.

Discussion

Explain the significance of what you found out. Relate the results to the problem or concerns mentioned in the introduction section. If the method affects the results, tell how and suggest changes. You can suggest or recommend further actions at the end of this section. Simply consider these questions:

Did you achieve your goal? (if you did not, say so and explain why)

What are the implications of your results for you and for your goals, for other people and for their goals?

What new questions do your results cause?

Progress Report

Progress reports inform the management about the status of a project. Such reports are regularly submitted throughout the life of a project in order to let the reader know whether or not work is progressing satisfactorily within the project's budget and time limitations.

The standard sections of a progress report are the following:

- Introduction
- Work completed
- Work scheduled
- problems

- **In the introduction**; name the project, define the time period covered by the report and state the purpose to inform readers about the current status of the project.
- **In the work completed section**; specify the time period, divide the project into major tasks and report the appropriate details.
- **In the work scheduled section**; explain the work that will occur on each major task in the next time period.
- **In the problems section**; discuss any special topics that require the attention of the reader.

Elements which make a document, a writing or a report appear informal.

- Contractions: Contractions like (it's, it'll, can't, won't) and so on instead of (it is, it will, cannot, will not) make a writing informal.
- Use of personal pronouns: Personal pronouns like (I, we, me, mine, our, us, he, she, it, him, her, his, they, them, their) and so on make a writing informal.
- Use of personal names, especially first names: Also make a writing informal or give it a personal touch. Personal titles should be used with names to avoid it.
- Similarly, shortening, blending and use of non standard and informal English expression also makes a writing appear informal. (Want to----wanna, going to----gonna, dad, mom, buddy and so on, so all such above mentioned elements should be avoided in a formal and standard writing/document/report.

NOTE: It may please be noted that it is the format and communication situation due to which reports are termed formal or informal. However, the above elements should be avoided, both in formal and informal reports and standard and formal language be used.

Sequence & steps for generating a formal report

(Research based long reports)

- Title page: Create a title page also called cover page. The title must reflect the central idea or scope of the project or report.
- Table of contents: Create a table of contents page(s) and leave it empty. This page should be filled after the completion of the report, once the chapters and page numbers have been finalized and matched.
- Executive summary or abstract: Create a page for executive summary or abstract and leave it empty. This page is to be filled when the summary will be written and the summary will only be written once the report has been finalized.
- Introduction: Provide a brief introduction of the project and objectives in this section.
- Background: Describe the problem, issue, topic or subject due to which the report is being written.

- Methodology or procedure: Describe in this section all those steps which have been taken to achieve the objectives of the report by using past tense here as these steps have already been taken.
- Results: Describe all the results of the project in this section, even those which were not intended or expected.
- Conclusions: Based upon the results, discuss the implications, pros and cons of the results of the project.
- Recommendations: Based upon the results and conclusions, propose and suggest recommendations, which are those steps or measures that should or should not be taken.
- Visual aids, glossary of terms, abbreviations and symbols: These things or any other additional information related to the report may be placed after the recommendations section.
- Summary or abstract: Summarize (chapter 6) the whole report and place the summary on the page left empty for it in the beginning.

- Editing: Edit/proof read the whole report, each chapter, each paragraph, each chunk, each sentence, check the tone; everything (chapter 4)
- Fill in the table of contents page, left empty before the executive summary page, in the beginning, by ensuring that the page numbers are accurately placed.
- Printing and binding: Get the report printed and jacketed/hard bound, and then presented to the audience with a covering letter, also called as transmittal letter(to be discussed in chapter Letters).

NOTE: It may please be noted that a formal report is always written following the style sheet, for establishing a consistent visual logic (chapter 3 Technical Writing Process) In the final year project FYP report writing, the style sheet will be provided by the project supervisor.